

N A E E M R I A D

B o r n 2 0 0 0 , C o l o m b o , S r i L a n k a



ABOUT

My journey began at the age of 7, when I would spend hours sketching figures. My mother, who herself was a painter, became my first inspiration, fostering my love for art. Both of my parents supported me wholeheartedly, although they never saw my artistic skills as a potential career path.

As I grew older, I found myself seeking a way to merge my passion for art with a profession that could sustain me. Graphic design became my chosen path, allowing me to utilize my artistic skills while also ensuring a steady income.

During the pandemic, I used my time in self isolation teaching myself 3D forms of art which led to my interests in Augmented Reality.

Word of mouth and social connections led me to the attention of MeshMinds in Singapore. Joining their team as a Creative Technologist, I merged art, technology, and sustainability, working on projects for organizations like UNEP, Meta, and Apple. It was a transformative experience, allowing me to flourish and expand my skills in AR.

At age 23 I finally decided to establish my career as an artist & express my love for sketching with my debut exhibition "Skin & Graphite".

EDUCATION

- 2016** : Pearson Edexcel International GCSE
O/Level (Brisbane International School, Sri Lanka)
- 2017 - 2019** : Foundation in Art and Design (Falmouth University, Sri Lanka)
- 2020** : Higher National Diploma in Graphic Design (Falmouth University, Sri Lanka)
- 2021** : Self-taught 3D Modeling & 3D painting
Self-taught Augmented Reality Art
(Meta Platform Filters/Lenses)

EXPERIENCE

2017 - 2018 : GRAPHIC DESIGNER AND STUDENT :

Leo Burnett MasterClass Programme 2018, Sri Lanka

2018 - 2021 : FREELANCE AND FULL TIME
GRAPHIC DESIGNER & SOCIAL MEDIA STRATEGIC HANDLE :

- findmyfare.com, Sri Lanka
- Da Vinci Global, Sri Lanka
- SNS ENTERTAINMENT : The Love Bar & The Attic

2019 - 2021 : ASSISTANT INTERIOR DESIGNER :

- The Monkey Business, Sri Lanka
- The Love Bar, Sri Lanka
- Gerard Mendis Chocolatier, Sri Lanka

2020 - 2021 : FREELANCE AR ARTIST :

- Multiple companies and clients

2021 - 2023 : CREATIVE TECHNOLOGIST :

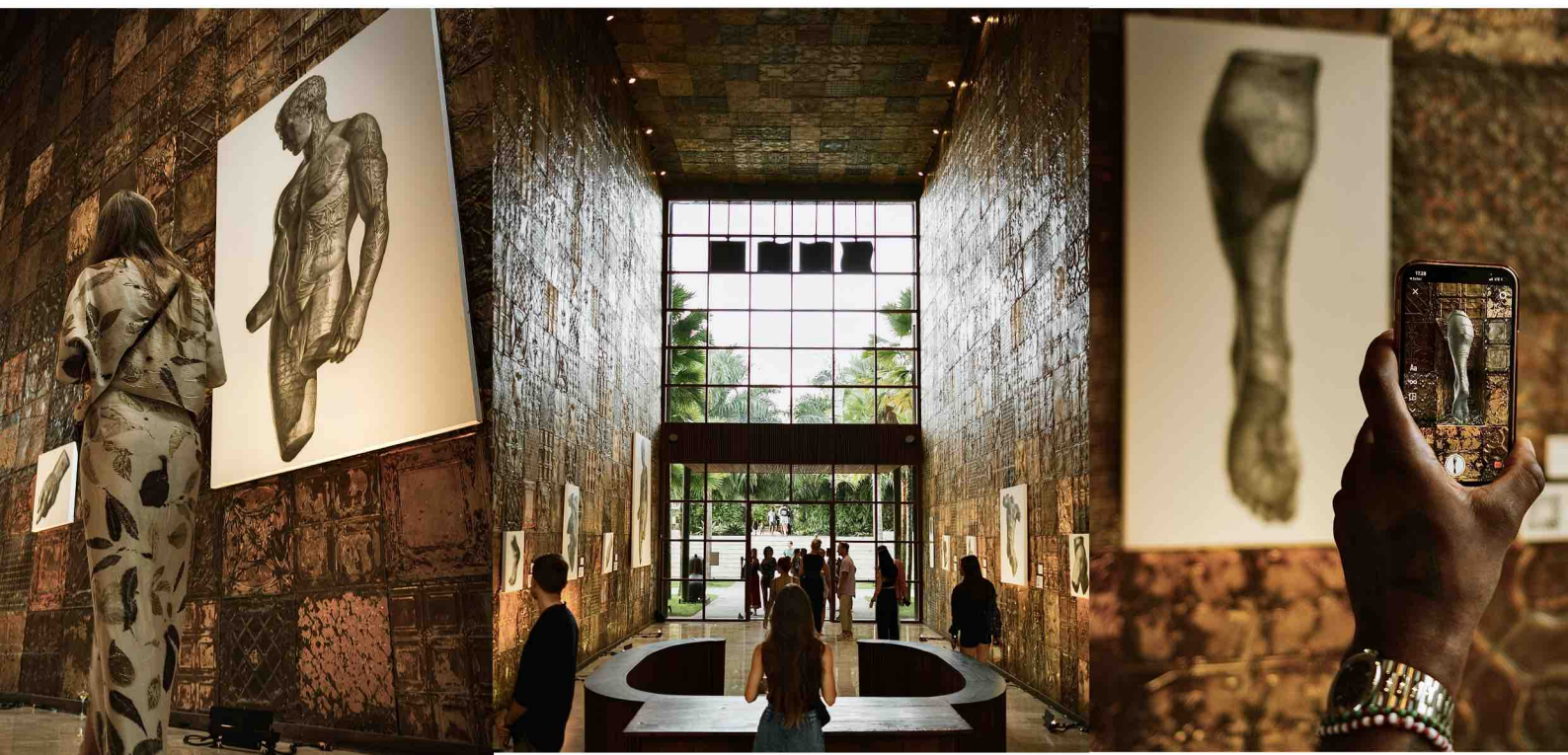
- Meta, Singapore
- MeshMinds & MeshMinds Foundation, Singapore
- United Nations Environmental Programme (UNEP), Singapore

EXHIBITIONS

JULY 2023 : Solo Exhibition, *SKIN & GRAPHITE*,
Harold Pieris Gallery, Lionel Wendt, Colombo, Sri Lanka



DECEMBER 2023 : Solo Exhibition, *FRAGMENTS*, as a part of 'Parq Art Space'
inauguration 'The Body of Work', Parq Ubud, Bali, Indonesia



PUBLICATIONS

HI!! MAGAZINE 2021
The Siren From Ceylon

HI!! MAGAZINE 2023
HOLLYWOOD ACTRESS
MERLE OBERON

HI!! MAGAZINE 2021
The Siren From Ceylon



The Art of illustration

NAEEM RIAD IS A SRI LANKAN ILLUSTRATOR AND ARTIST. HIS BOLD AND DETAILED WORK AS SEEN IN THIS ISSUE'S FEATURE ON NINA DYER BEARS TESTIMONY TO HIS INFINITE TALENT

Words: Tina Edward Gunawardhana



For talented illustrator Naeem Riad, the world is indeed his oyster. The combination of his creative aura and innate talent holds him in good stead as he embarks on a career as an illustrator and artist.

At just 20 years old, on the cusp of adulthood, Naeem's talent was spotted by Andre Estefan, a svengali of sorts who took Naeem under his wing and nurtured his artistic ability.

Naeem was inspired by his mother who was a painter. He says "my mum was not only an artist but also someone who was creative with her work in the kitchen. This inspired me. When she realised I had a leaning towards the arts, she encouraged me to pursue this path."

Describing his journey in to the field of illustration, Naeem adds "I've been sketching since I was five years and my very first sketches were of Barbie and the Nutcracker for which I am still made fun of. The journey has been long since it was a process from pencil and paper and finally into the digital medium."

Although Naeem has a Higher National Diploma in Graphic Design he claims that he is self-taught in most aspects of art and illustration. "I've developed my skills purely by just observing images closely."

"The light, shadow, texture and detail in everything works, and also by observing other artists and their work. I wouldn't say I have a specific style but

I loved researching and illustrating the feature on Nina Dyer for the Hi!! magazine. This was my first ever professional commission and I enjoyed creating vintage images

I like to create my work in different forms from imagery to abstract and a combination of sorts."

Speaking of the moment he was commissioned by Hi!! magazine to create the illustrations for the Nina Dyer article (pages 20 to 27) Naeem says "I was very excited because it was my first commission for a magazine and the best part is that I love illustrating vintage styled work. Researching Nina Dyer was extremely educational and I was intrigued to find out how closely she was connected to Ceylon."

His work is lifelike and his illustrations bear an uncanny resemblance to the subject. Naeem carefully studies the image absorbing each detail, from tiny smile lines to more prominent features. He captures every detail and replicates it in his illustrations "I have always enjoyed drawing the human body. However drawing faces has always been something I've challenged myself with."

"One of the things that always comes into consideration when I sketch a face are the eyes, it's the very first thing I start with every time I sketch a face. Eyes are my thing," he added.

In this current climate where distractions are a plenty, Naeem has his eyes fixed firmly on the bigger picture. "I have a collection of my work from my early teen years and I go through it often to view my progress and how my technique has evolved, it motivates me to continue to create so I can be better."

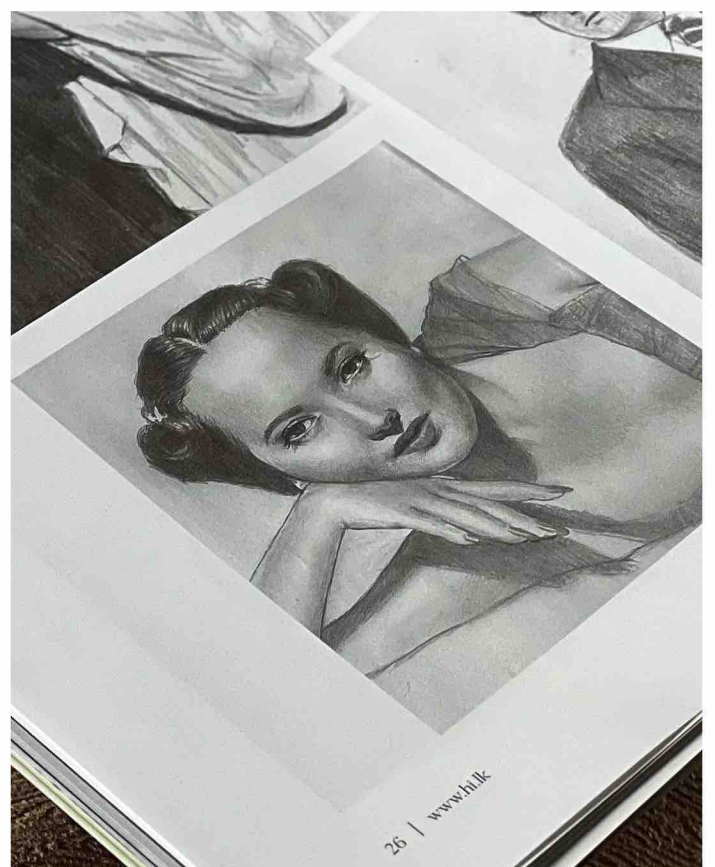
With his first professional commission, the series of sketches for the feature on Nina Dyer under his wing, Naeem is focused on holding his maiden exhibition under the encouraging, watchful and critical eye of Andre who is his mentor and guiding light.

"I am very excited as I am working towards my first solo exhibition at the moment. I was meant to hold my exhibition in 2020 but Covid-19 intervened. However I am working towards having an exhibition this year. I have used the extra time constructively and I have created some even better work."



HI!! MAGAZINE 2023

HOLLYWOOD ACTRESS MERLE OBERON



Skin & Graphite

TALENTED ARTIST, **NAEEM RIAD** EXHIBITS 'SKIN AND GRAPHITE', A LOVE LETTER CELEBRATING AND UNRAVELLING THE POWER OF SELF-EXPRESSION

Words: Tiranya Yalindee Ranasinghe



'Skin and Graphite' has finally become a long-awaited dream come true for Naeem, the skilled illustrator. You may already be familiar with some of his work from our previous issues, such as his exquisite illustrations of actress

Merle Oberon and Nina Dyer. Naeem's journey as an artist began at the tender age of 7, where he would lose himself in hours of sketching. His mother, a painter, played a pivotal role as his first inspiration, igniting his love for art. As he grew older, Naeem sought to combine his artistic talents with a stable profession, leading him to pursue Graphic Design.

At 19, fate introduced him to Andre Esteaf, who not only became his mentor but also a father figure. This moment marked a significant turning point in his life. Subsequently, Naeem joined Meshminds in Singapore as a Creative Technologist, working on noteworthy projects for major organizations like Meta, Apple, and UNEP.

As COVID-19 gradually receded, Naeem made the bold decision to transform his dream of holding an exhibition into a tangible reality. This exhibition, for him, is a reflection of the unwavering support from his parents, the continuous guidance from his mentor, and the profound self-discovery he has experienced throughout his artistic journey.

What inspired 'Skin and Graphite'?

As an artist, I am deeply passionate about my craft, and my inspiration comes from my personal interests and experiences. The concept of "Skin & Graphite" excited me immensely. It brings together two significant aspects of my artistic journey, my love for the traditional black and white graphite pencil work that I started with as a young artist, and the exploration of my own sexual interests. This exhibition was a celebration of my roots, where I began my artistic exploration with pencil in hand, and how that journey has intertwined with the exploration of my own sexuality, shaping my unique creative voice.

Give us a bit of insight into the process of working on this project?

The genesis of this project dates back three years ago when the idea first took root. However, the initial concept for the exhibition was quite different from what it has become today. The process of bringing it to life has been a long and transformative journey.

The project's evolution was significantly influenced by the circumstances of the Covid pandemic and my time spent living between Bali and Singapore for several months. These experiences provided me with a new perspective, prompting me to re-evaluate my artistic direction and what I truly wanted to convey through this exhibition.

During this period of reflection, I discovered my niche, a focus that deeply resonated with me. Excited about the new direction, I shared my thoughts and ideas with Stefan, who has been a long-time collaborator. Stefan's expertise in the creative business played a vital role in shaping the vision for the exhibition. His input and distinct approach helped refine the concept and bring it into clearer focus.

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Together, we honed the exhibition's theme and refined the selection of artworks that would best represent my journey and the new narrative I sought to share with the world. Our collaborative synergy, borne out of years of working together, streamlined the decision-making process, and we soon found ourselves moving ahead with confidence.

What were some of the challenges you encountered during this project?

One of the significant hurdles was securing proper working materials and finding suitable live models for my artistic vision. In Sri Lanka, access to specialized art materials and resources can be limited, making it essential to be resourceful and creative in obtaining what I needed for my artwork. Additionally, finding live models who were willing to participate and fit the specific requirements of the project proved to be a challenge.

To address the limitations in finding local models, I decided to embrace the global nature of the internet. Working with models from across the globe became the solution to the challenges I faced. Through this process, I learned the value of adaptability and embracing technology as a means to overcome traditional constraints. The internet not only connected me with models worldwide but also introduced me to new artistic influences and perspectives from different corners of the world.

What message do you wish to communicate through this project?
From the age of 14, nude art has been a profound inspiration in my life. However, as a

young individual, I grappled with the societal pressures and felt the need to conceal my artistic creations. Now, with "Skin & Graphite," I have found the courage to break free from those constraints and embrace my true self. Through this exhibition, my mission is to empower other queer artists in Sri Lanka to fearlessly express their unique perspectives, irrespective of societal expectations.

I want to create a safe space where artists can boldly explore their creativity, unapologetically celebrating their identity and experiences. For me, being a nudist is an integral part of my identity, and I firmly believe that there is no shame in embracing our own sexuality.

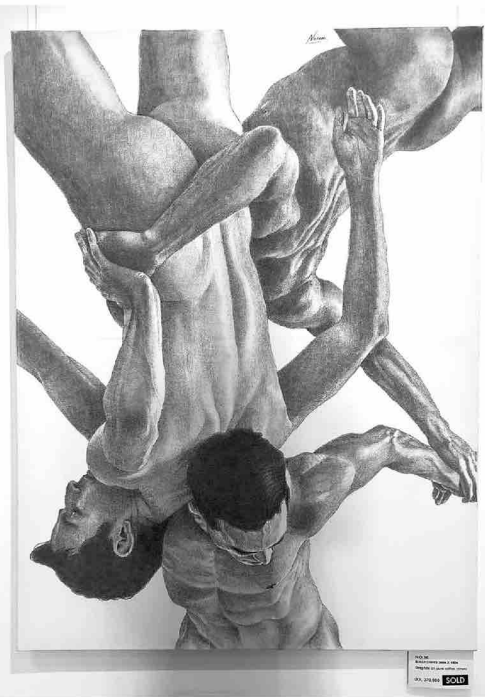
We should be free to express ourselves without judgment or societal stigma. Through my art, I aim to challenge traditional norms and advocate for body positivity, self-acceptance, and sexual liberation.

Which drawing is your favourite in this series?

Skin No.32 holds a special place in my heart as it takes the spotlight as the final piece in my exhibition. This artwork is not only one of the largest but also the most intricately detailed, bringing together the world of traditional art and my expertise as an AR creative technologist.

This unique blend of traditional and augmented reality art offers a mesmerizing and immersive encounter, inviting the audience to engage with the artwork on a whole new level.

For me, Skin No.32 symbolizes the convergence of art and technology, where the creative possibilities are limitless.

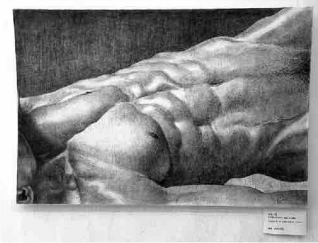


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How would you describe your artistic style? Are there any specific influences or inspirations that shape your work?

I am a versatile and curious artist, drawn to the allure of various mediums, ranging from traditional tools like pencils, paints, and paper to modern digital illustrations, 3D sculpting, and Augmented Reality. Throughout the years, I have been a dedicated self-learner, acquiring a diverse set of skills across these mediums, but it is in the realm of graphite pencil sketches where my creativity truly flourishes. As an artist, I don't confine myself to a specific style; instead, I embrace the freedom to explore and draw inspiration from various artists' works. Yes, I find myself most drawn to realism, striving to recreate art that exudes a sense of authenticity and lifelike presence. This penchant for realism is deeply rooted in my passion for photography and video games, where the intricate details, interplay of light and shadow, depth, texture, and subtle nuances hold immense fascination for me.

What do you have in the pipeline for your next project?
That's a surprise but rest assured it will be the next step.



"Skin & Graphite" brings together two significant aspects of my artistic journey, my love for the traditional black and white graphite pencil work and the exploration of my own sexual interests

PRESS : COLLECTIVE APP FEATURE, LAS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA, USA



Q: What is your favorite project you have worked on and why?

A: My favorite project is one of my latest, titled *Fragments*. 'Fragments' explores the interplay of digital technology within classical portraiture and figurative drawing. I weave together academic techniques on the verge of obsolescence with digital tools.

Inspired by Ancient Greek statues, I deviate from convention by forgoing live models, opting instead for 3D sculpting that eliminates direct human interaction. These deliberately unfinished figures metamorphose into academic graphite sketches on canvas, only to undergo yet another transformation through the incorporation of AR. Here, **I confront the transiency of all classical norms**, challenging the limitations imposed by contemporary digital mediums.

My oeuvre extends beyond technical experimentation; it delves into the socio-cultural intricacies surrounding the male body, urging a reconsideration of societal perceptions. 'Fragments' emerges as an artistic discourse that not only probes the evolving dynamics between classical art and technology but also **fosters a nuanced contemplation of queerness** within this contextual framework.

Q: Who are your queer role-models?

A: Andy Warhol and Tom of Finland are my queer role models, although Tom's work was something I really connected with.

Tom of Finland was a major role model to me and played a pivotal role in my sexual awakening at the age of 14, when I myself would sketch homoerotic art, **but would eventually have to destroy them to hide my sexuality**.

Tom's work was of fantasy and pleasure which I see as one of the purest forms of art. To have an intimate relationship with what you create, the feeling you create for yourself and others that view your art.

ART/PEOPLE

Naeem Riad on 'SKIN & GRAPHITE'

BY DIMITHRI WJESINGHE

Born and raised in Sri Lanka, Naeem Riad is a sketch artist currently based between Sri Lanka, Bali in Indonesia, and Singapore. He is presently a freelance creative technologist at MeshMinds Singapore and has excelled as a creative, honing his skills over the years in multiple disciplines of sketching, digital illustrations, 2D and 3D animations, 3D sculpting, and Augmented Reality.

Marking an incredibly significant milestone in his career, Naeem held his debut art exhibition titled 'Skin & Graphite: An exhibition of fine art by Naeem Riad' at the Harold Peiris Gallery, Lionel Wendt on 7 and 8 July. Curated by Andre Estefan, the exhibition concept centred on "celebrating the allure of the male anatomy and unravelling the power of self-expression".

The Sunday Morning Brunch embarked on a deep dive with Naeem about his debut exhibition, his career motivations as an artist, and what is in store for the young talent.

→ You define yourself as a sketch artist. In terms of your skills and the pursuit of a career, how and when did you decide that this was your calling?

I define myself as a sketch artist because of where my journey began – at the age of five or seven, sketching characters from my favourite shows. Following this, my mother shared with me how she used to paint and she became one of the first people who inspired me to draw. She was intrigued by the arts and both my parents fully supported me in my art as a hobby, but never really saw it as something that would make an income in the future.

Although I had no vision of a clear path in sketching as a profession, following the end of my school years, I took an interest in work that would make me an income; something that would let me use my skills in art as well as make a profit – graphic design.

I completed a foundation course in design at the age of 17 and began working as a freelance graphic designer for advertising agencies right after.

At 19, I met Stefan Andre Joachim, who saw potential in me



as an artist. I began working for his fashion company Andre Estefan as a graphic designer, assisting him on projects and events and building my portfolio, skills, as well as knowledge in the world of design. Stefan is, to this date, my mentor and father figure.

Initially, my first exhibition was titled 'NaeemTeen' when I was 19 years old, which seemed fitting at the time. It was scheduled to take place on 19 March 2019. Unfortunately, due to the Covid-19 pandemic, the exhibition had to be cancelled. During the period of social distancing, I utilised the time to teach myself 3D art by observing the works of other talented artists online. Eventually, I developed an interest in Augmented Reality (AR) and started incorporating my 3D skills into creating face filters for my social media using Meta Spark by Meta.

Through social media and a network of connections, my work caught the attention of MeshMinds in Singapore. I joined the MeshMinds team as a Creative Technologist, utilising AR to merge art, technology, and sustainability to protect our culture and the environment in the digital age. During my tenure with MeshMinds, I had the opportunity to design projects for UNEP, Meta, and Apple, aiming to educate, enable, and empower creators in shaping our collective future. My time at MeshMinds allowed me to flourish and expand my skills and knowledge in AR.

As the pandemic drew to a close, I decided that it was finally time to plan my first exhibition, four years after its originally intended date. Over this time, I have grown to perceive myself more as an artist rather than solely a technologist. Therefore, I decided to make graphite the main focus of this exhibition, as it is the fundamental medium that nurtured

my passion for art during my childhood.

→ What would you say has inspired you the most over the years to pursue art as both a career and a passion?

Seeing other artists create is what inspires me the most – seeing what a creative person is capable of and how they can reach their full potential. This is why I am constantly learning throughout my journey.

In all honesty, I never imagined that my art would build a career for me, since when I was younger I could see that artists didn't really get to build a career in their work unless they were well known or well-connected in the industry and the less fortunate always seemed to be exploited.

Although that was the case, I still couldn't imagine myself at a 9-5 desk job creating for others; I knew that would be torture for the artist inside me.

I would say the thing that inspires me the most to pursue art as both a career and passion is my happiness and free will; that feeling of fullness and knowing

that creating art is what drives me and brings me joy. I believe that anything that you do for a living should bring you joy. That is what inspires me.

→ How would you describe your style of work, i.e. what is your identity as an artist?

I am an artist of interest and every medium interests me, from pencil, paint, and paper to digital illustrations, 3D sculpting, and AR.

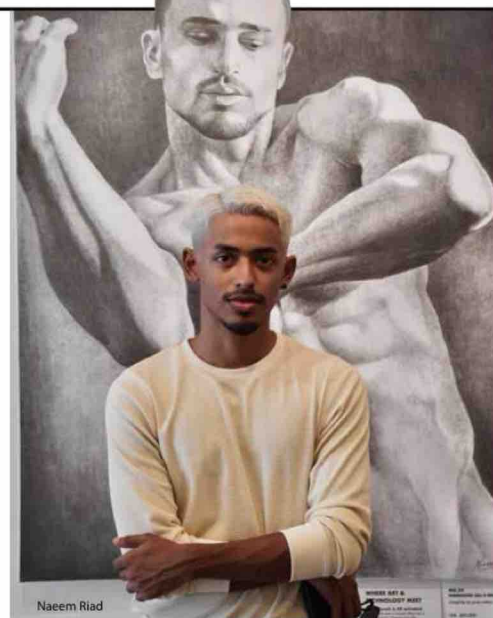
Because of my interest in many mediums, I tend to self-teach, as I have throughout the years, and have picked up many skills. Although I have knowledge in other mediums, I feel most creative and skilled in the medium of graphite pencil sketches.

I wouldn't say I have a specific style as I like to try to mimic many other artists' work, but my style is mostly realism as I enjoy creating art that looks and feels real. I try to achieve this in most of the mediums I use.

My love for realism comes from my love for photography and video games; it's all in the details – the focus on the light and shadow,



Naeem Riad and Stefan Andre Joachim



the depth, the texture, and the finest of features.

→ Tell us about 'Skin & Graphite'.

My debut art exhibition 'Skin & Graphite' marks a significant milestone in my artistic journey, showcasing my profound dedication to the normalisation of nude art and the celebration of self-expression within a society that often discourages it. My current body of work is a testament to my artistic vision, drawing inspiration from male anatomy.

'Skin & Graphite' is a message to everyone to know that it is okay to sexualise oneself and that anyone can feel sexy without feeling judged. My exhibition invites viewers to challenge societal norms and explore the profound beauty and sensuality that lies within every individual.

→ What is your reasoning for selecting nude art as part of your debut exhibition?

One reason is because I am a nudist. My partner and I are constantly nude in our home, wherever in the world that may be. It isn't something that is sexual, but has more to do with feeling free and comfortable in our skin.

Nude art has been an inspiration to me ever since the age of 14, when I first came across Tom of Finland, an artist who created stylised highly masculinised homoerotic art and influenced late 20th century queer culture.

After coming across many more nude portrait artists like Tom of Finland, I began to take an interest in creating similar work at a young age, but since I hid the fact that I was gay at the time, I would always have to throw them away before they could be found.

→ What are your hopes for this exhibition and what do you wish for those who experience it to take away from it?

I hope this exhibition inspires other queer artists in Sri Lanka

to create whatever makes them happy and let them know that they shouldn't be afraid to express what they feel, no matter what society says. Art can be whatever you want it to be and that no one can tell you what you should and should not create.

→ Now that the public has had a chance to experience your work, how do you feel looking back and about the feedback you have received?

In all honesty, I wasn't quite confident that I would get supportive feedback regarding the images I've created, as the mindset of many Sri Lankans towards nudity is quite negative. To my surprise, I was praised for what I had created. A majority of the feedback that I received on my artwork was that it was not something you would expect in Sri Lanka, but something you would expect in Europe.

The audience was pleased to see the nude male figure portrayed in such a way that most artists in Sri Lanka do with the nude female figure.

I was also praised by the audience for the AR experiences I had created, as it was some viewers' first time experiencing something like this. Most viewers commented that this was something that you would only experience overseas.

→ What are your plans for the future?

I'm looking to create more work and hold many more exhibitions, hopefully overseas as well. I plan to study more about fine arts and realism, as I feel I have a lot more to learn and am yet to reach my full potential. I also hope to teach others how to create and reach their potential.

I also plan to one day own a gallery space in Europe as well as Sri Lanka. A space that would exhibit and nurture young artists' talent – artists struggling to get their work seen.

NAEEM RIAD

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